

MEDIEVAL

Assessment Question: How has medicine changed from c1250 to the modern day?

Name:

Class:

Progress & Assessment Tracker	Effort	Level	Teacher Comments
L1: KT1.1: What did Medieval people believe caused illness?			
L2: KT1.2: How did Medieval people try to prevent and treat disease?			
L3: KT1.3: How did people respond to the Black Death?			
Final Unit Grade:			



Section B: Thematic Study (Medicine in Britain)

This section tests your understanding of change, continuity, and causation across 800 years of British medicine.

Question 3: Explain One Similarity or Difference...

4
Marks

5
mins

5:00

TARGET OBJECTIVE

AO2 (Analyse similarity and difference across historical periods)

THE SYMMETRICAL SPLICING METHOD

[Comparative Thesis]

[Era 1: Context]

[Era 2: Matching Context]

Examiner Red Flags

The "Two-Story" Essay:

Writing a block of facts about the first era, followed by a

Grade 9 Checklist

Immediate Comparison:

Does my very first sentence make a direct comparison

separate block about the second era without linking them is capped at 2 marks.

Concept Slippage: If the question asks about prevention, do not write about treatment.

Chronological Blunders: Placing key developments in the wrong century.

using a comparative connective?

Symmetrical Alignment: Do the details I provide for Era 2 directly match the theme of Era 1?

Single-Paragraph Splicing: Is my answer written as a single, cohesive paragraph?

Question 4: Explain Why... (Causation)

12
Marks

15-18
mins

18:00

TARGET OBJECTIVE

AO2 (Analyse causation) and AO1 (Demonstrate precise knowledge)

THE THREE-CAUSAL-PILLARS LAYOUT

No Introduction

Para 1

Stimulus A

Para 2

Stimulus B

Para 3

Own Knowledge

Examiner Red Flags

The Stimulus Cap: Failing to introduce an independent third factor from your own knowledge caps your mark at 8/12.

The Narrative Biography

Trap: Writing a chronological story instead of explaining *why* their work led to rapid progress.

Grade 9 Checklist

The Rule of Three: Have I structured my answer into exactly three separate paragraphs?

Causal Topic Openers: Does the first sentence of each paragraph state a clear, analytical cause?

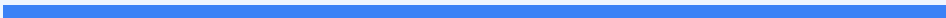
Double Causal Connectives: Have I used the Edexcel Connective Chain ("Consequently...", "This meant that...") at least twice per paragraph?

Question 5 & 6: Evaluative Essay

16+4
Marks

25-30
mins

30:00



TARGET OBJECTIVE

AO2 (Evaluate significance/change) and AO1 (Wide-ranging knowledge)

THE GRADE 9 JUDGMENT ARC

1

Intro

(Thesis & Criteria)

2

FOR

(Given Factor)

3

AGAINST

(Own Knowledge)

4

Conclusion

(Apply Criteria)

Examiner Red Flags

The One-Sided Argument:

Failing to analyze alternative factors traps your essay at Level 2 (8 marks).

"Fencing" Conclusions:

Reaching a conclusion that simply states both sides were equally important.

Concept Slippage: Treating "care" and "treatment" as identical.

Grade 9 Checklist

Explicit Evaluation Criteria:

Have I defined the historical criteria I will use to measure the statement?

The Argument AGAINST:

Have I evaluated alternative factors using my own knowledge?

Substantiated Verdict: Have I explicitly applied the criteria established in my intro to justify which factor was most significant?

SPaG: Have I capitalized proper nouns and correctly spelled specialist terms?

L1: KT1.1: What did Medieval people believe caused illness?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain how supernatural and religious factors influenced beliefs about the cause of illness.
- ☐ Analyse the rational, natural theories of disease used in medieval England.

During the medieval period, life was difficult, and sudden illness was terrifying. Without microscopes or an understanding of germs, people desperately sought ways to make sense of sickness. The explanations they relied on—ranging from God’s wrath to the alignment of the stars and the imbalance of bodily fluids—shaped every aspect of medical treatment for centuries. Understanding these beliefs is the key to understanding all of medieval medicine.

Did you know?

- 5th Century BCE: The era when the Ancient Greek doctor Hippocrates first developed the foundational Theory of the Four Humours.
- 4: The exact number of bodily fluids (blood, phlegm, yellow bile, black bile) that medieval doctors believed dictated human health and disease.
- 1345: The year an unusual planetary alignment occurred, which medieval astrologers and physicians blamed for causing the devastating Black Death shortly after.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 5

1. What does the term 'public health' refer to?

2. Name one ancient civilization that influenced later medical ideas.

3. Why was the Catholic Church so powerful in the Middle Ages?

4. Explain how religion might both help and hinder medical progress.

5. To what extent were ancient ideas like those of Hippocrates still influential in c1250?

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Miasma Four Humours Theory of Opposites
--

In medieval England, medical beliefs were heavily dominated by ancient theories rather than scientific observation. Under the popular _____ theory, a patient's temperature or cold was diagnosed as a bodily imbalance. To treat a cold, a physician might use Galen's _____ to recommend eating hot and dry spices. However, when entire towns fell ill, people often blamed _____, believing that foul-smelling air from rotting waste in the streets was poisoning their lungs.

Q1. Identify one reason why the Church promoted Galen's ideas.

Q2. Describe the Theory of the Four Humours.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q3)

Why did the Church promote the work of the ancient Roman doctor Galen?

- ☐ A. Because Galen proved that God sent diseases as a punishment.
 - ☐ B. Because Galen's theory of a perfectly designed body fit Christian creation theology.
 - ☐ C. Because Galen was a devout Christian.
 - ☐ D. Because he was the personal physician to the Pope.
-

Q4. Explain how astrology was used in medieval medicine.

Q5. Evaluate the significance of the Church in holding back medical progress in the Middle Ages.

Pair & Share Activity

Prompt: Which factor was the most powerful barrier to medieval medical progress: the absolute authority of the Christian Church, or the logical appeal of the Theory of the Four Humours?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence from the sources (e.g., Church control of universities/libraries, or how symptoms like sneezing phlegm seemed to prove the humours existed).

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over the Medieval Church's Impact on Medicine

For decades, traditional historians portrayed the medieval Catholic Church as a dogmatic institution that actively and deliberately stifled medical progress by banning dissections and imprisoning independent researchers like Roger Bacon. However, modern revisionist historians argue that the Church was not deliberately preventing progress. They point out that without the Church's libraries, the vital ancient medical texts of Hippocrates and Galen would have been lost entirely. Furthermore, they argue that the level of medieval technology meant that microbes could not be observed anyway, meaning that treatment would remain ineffective regardless of religious dominance, and that the Church was the only institution actively offering organised care to the sick through monastic hospitals.

GCSE Exam Practice

Q6. The Theory of the Four Humours was the main idea about the cause of disease in the Middle Ages. How far do you agree? Explain your answer. (16 marks) You may use the following in your answer:

â€¢ Galen

â€¢ the Church

You must also use information of your own.

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Q Explain why there was so little progress in understanding the causes of disease during the Middle Ages. (12 marks)

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1. Explain why there was so little change in ideas about the cause of disease in the years c.1250â€”c.1500. (12 marks)

You may use the following in your answer:

- The Church
- Galen

You must also use information of your own.

[illegible]

General Notes

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☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

L2: KT1.2: How did Medieval people try to prevent and treat disease?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the connection between medieval beliefs about disease and their approaches to treatment and prevention.
- ☐ Evaluate the roles, training, and accessibility of different medical healers in medieval society.

In medieval England, a lack of scientific knowledge meant treatments were heavily based on religion, superstition, and the Ancient Greeks. Care was mostly provided at home by women, while the wealthy paid for university-trained physicians. The methods used to treat and prevent sickness directly matched people's beliefs about what caused disease, resulting in a bizarre mix of herbal remedies, prayer, and drastic measures like bloodletting to balance the body.

Did you know?

- 1,100: The approximate number of hospitals operating in England by the year 1500, mostly run by the Catholic Church.
- 7 to 10: The number of years a physician spent training at a university, mostly reading the ancient books of Hippocrates and Galen rather than treating patients.
- 1215: The year a Church decree formally forbade clergymen (many of whom were physicians) from carrying out surgical operations that involved cutting the patient.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 6

1. Which Ancient Greek physician originally created the Theory of the Four Humours?

2. How did the Church explain the cause of disease?

3. What was 'miasma'?

4. Why did the Church promote the ideas of Galen?

5. Explain why astrology was used to diagnose illness in the medieval period.

6. Recall: Who was Roger Bacon and what was their key contribution to medicine?

Vocabulary Check

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

Phlebotomy Regimen Sanitatis Theriaca

Your Sentence:

Q1. Identify one supernatural method used to prevent disease.

Q2. Describe the process of bloodletting.

Q3. Explain how the Theory of Opposites was used in treatments.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q4)

What was the main difference between an apothecary and a physician?

- ☐ A. Physicians performed surgery, apothecaries diagnosed illness.
- ☐ B. Apothecaries mixed herbal remedies based on experience, while physicians diagnosed using astrology and ancient books.
- ☐ C. Apothecaries were trained at university, physicians were not.

☐ D. Physicians were always monks, apothecaries were always women.

Q5. To what extent were medieval treatments dangerous for patients?

Pair & Share Activity

Prompt: If you were a medieval peasant, who would you trust more to care for your family: an expensive university-trained physician who diagnosed using urine and star charts, or a female family member treating you in the home with herbal remedies?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence from the sources (such as the Paston family letters showing deep distrust of professional physicians, or the fact that women treated families for free with garden herbs like marigolds and clover).

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over the Effectiveness of Medieval Hospitals

Traditional historical accounts often dismissed medieval hospitals as dirty, unhygienic places of death where patients shared beds and received no real medicine. However, modern revisionist historians point out that judged by medieval standards, monastic hospitals actually maintained high standards of cleanliness, as bed linens and clothing were regularly washed by nuns. While they did not perform surgery and excluded infectious patients to prevent the spread of disease, they provided crucial spiritual care, warmth, and nutritious food. For patients not suffering from terminal illnesses, monastic care focusing on 'care, not cure' was highly successful in allowing the body to rest and recover in a comfortable, sanitary environment.

GCSE Exam Practice

Q6. "In the years c1250–c1500, the physician was the most important person providing care and treatment." How far do you agree? Explain your answer. (16 marks + 4 marks for SPaG)

[illegible]

Q Explain why bleeding and purging were such common treatments in the medieval period (c1250â€"c1500). (12 marks)

1. Explain why there was little change in the care provided by hospitals in the period c.1250â€”c.1500. (12 marks)

- Monks and nuns
- infectious diseases

[illegible]

General Notes

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Teacher Comment:

L3: KT1.3: How did people respond to the Black Death?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the religious and supernatural responses to the Black Death.
- ☐ Analyse the rational and governmental methods used to prevent and treat the plague.

In 1348, a devastating pandemic known as the Black Death struck England, rapidly wiping out at least a third of the population. Because medieval people had no scientific understanding of bacteria or germs, they desperately blamed the crisis on God, astrology, and foul air. This catastrophic event reveals the horrifying reality of medieval medicine, highlighting how powerless people were when forced to rely on religion and ancient, flawed theories in the face of a true public health emergency.

Did you know?

- 1348: The exact year the Black Death first arrived in England, spreading rapidly across the country.
- One-third: The estimated proportion of the English population killed by the plague in just over a year.
- Buboes: The dark, painful, pus-filled swellings in the armpit or groin that gave the bubonic plague its name.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 6

1. Name one religious treatment used in the medieval period.

2. What was the purpose of 'bleeding' or 'purging'?

3. Who were the 'flagellants'?

4. Explain the role of the apothecary in medieval medicine.

5. How effective were medieval hospitals at treating disease?

6. Recall: Who was Roger Bacon and what was their key contribution to medicine?

Vocabulary Check

Write a clear definition and a historically accurate sentence for the term: **Buboes**

Q1. Identify the true cause of the Black Death.

Q2. Describe two ways people tried to prevent the Black Death.

Q3. Explain why the government's response to the Black Death failed.

Q4. Evaluate the impact of the Black Death on medieval society.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q5)

Why were the government's orders to clean the streets completely ineffective at stopping the Black Death?

- ☐ A. Because the peasants refused to obey the King's laws.
 - ☐ B. Because the disease was actually a punishment from God.
 - ☐ C. Because they were trying to remove bad smells (miasma), but ignored the rats and fleas that actually spread the disease.
 - ☐ D. Because the dirt on the streets was actually killing the germs.
-

Pair & Share Activity

Prompt: Was the medieval response to the Black Death dominated more by desperate spiritual panic or by logical, rational attempts at disease prevention based on the scientific ideas of the time?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence (e.g., the public whipping of the flagellants vs. mayors ordering rakers to clear dung and waste from the streets to stop bad air).

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over the Socio-Economic Impact of the Black Death

Historians are deeply divided over the long-term impact of the Black Death on medieval English society. Traditional historians, such as G.M. Trevelyan, argued that the demographic catastrophe was a massive watershed of progress—the crucial turning point that caused severe labor shortages, ended feudalism, and paved the way for the Renaissance and Industrial Revolution. Conversely, modern revisionist historians argue that the Black Death did not suddenly destroy the feudal system overnight. Instead, they suggest it merely accelerated economic trends that were already underway, pointing to the immediate return of the plague every 10 to 20 years which caused prolonged economic depression and stagnation, rather than rapid modernizing progress.

GCSE Exam Practice

Q6. ~The main reason why medical care and treatment was ineffective during the medieval period was because medical knowledge was based on Galen's ideas.~™ How far do you agree? Explain your answer. (16 marks) You may use the following in your answer:

â€¢ bloodletting

â€¢ dissection

You must also use information of your own.

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Q Explain why the Black Death spread so rapidly in Britain in 1348. (12 marks)

1. "The main reason why medical care and treatment was ineffective during the medieval period (c1250–c1500) was because medical knowledge was based on Galen's ideas." How far do you agree? Explain your answer. (16 marks + 4 marks for SPaG) (16 marks)

- The Four Humours
- The Black Death

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General Notes

[illegible]

- ☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

Factors Overview: Medieval

Edexcel focuses heavily on the factors that drove medical progress (or held it back). For each factor below, write one specific historical example from this period that either helped or hindered medical progress.

Factor	Specific Historical Example & Impact
Individuals	
The Church & Religion	
Government & Wealth	
Science & Technology	
Attitudes in Society	
War	

Factor	Specific Historical Example & Impact